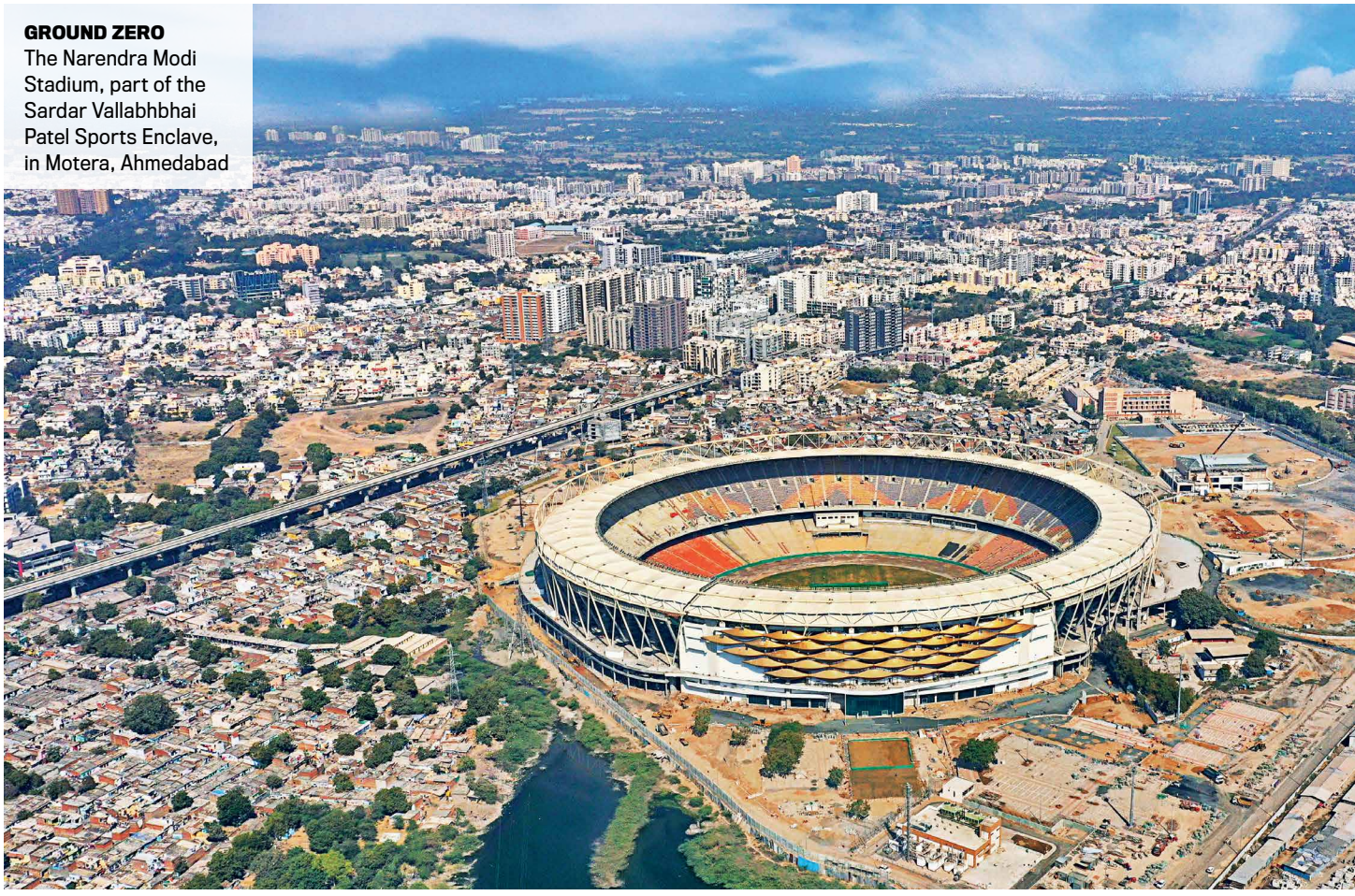


GROUND ZERO
The Narendra Modi Stadium, part of the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Sports Enclave, in Motera, Ahmedabad

SPORTS

GUJARAT'S OLYMPICS PUSH

By Jumana Shah

Come 2036 and Ahmedabad and Gandhinagar in Prime Minister Narendra Modi's home state Gujarat may well be hosting the Summer Olympics. Why 2036? Well, the next three hosts have already been finalised—Paris in 2024, Los Angeles in 2028 and Brisbane in 2032. India has already communicated the desire to host the 2036 edition to the International Olympic Committee (IOC), though officials privy to the development say "formal engagement" will begin at the global body's next meeting scheduled in Mumbai in September.

Many a nation has used big-ticket sporting events to showcase its soft power, and the PM Modi-led Union government is driven by the same urge to enhance the country's global standing. Since the idea was first mooted in early 2021, it has gathered steam in political circles, while bureaucrats in Gujarat have been busy preparing the government's pitch to be tabled before the IOC. At the core of the proposal is the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel (SVP) Sports Enclave, located along the Sabarmati riverfront in Ahmedabad's Motera, which will house venues for over 20 Olympics sports. The opening ceremony is proposed at the Narendra Modi Stadium, the world's biggest cricket stadium with a 132,000 seating capacity, which is a part of the sports enclave (see *Mission 2036*).

A senior government official involved in preparing the proposal says, "We are fairly confident India will bag the 2036 Olympics hosting rights, as several economies much smaller in size have hosted the event more than once." The main objective of the pitch is to showcase the availability of infrastructure in the twin cities. The SVP Sports Enclave is quite ideally located in an urban developing area, the official explains further, which means the basic infrastructure is already in place, yet there are large tracts available for new development.